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Author(s): Arlene B. Tickner

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Latin American IR and the Primacy of *lo práctico*¹

ARLENE B. TICKNER

Department of Political Science, Universidad de los Andes

This article traces the general historical development of international relations (IR) thinking in Latin America based upon the influence of key intellectual, political, economic, social, and cultural factors. In particular, the ways in which state needs, foreign policy practices, the development of the social sciences, and US IR knowledge have influenced Latin American understandings of the “international” since the postwar period are explored.

During the past decade, the claim that dominant international relations (IR) theories’ incapacity to understand fundamental issues of global import warrants tapping into alternative sources of knowledge has become commonplace. Among the key targets of the field’s efforts to visibilize non-conventional subjects and to expand its boundaries, the Third World² has figured prominently, mainly because both IR’s central narratives and the academic practices that it cultivates have reinforced peripheral countries’ and scholars’ irrelevance to the study of international politics. Critical IR scholarship increasingly argues that when the third world replaces the great powers as authors of theory, new types of problems, research agendas, and ways of knowing come into view.³ And yet, IR studies in the non-core have often been described in terms of their adherence to core, mainly US models, and the lack of interest in theory building (Holsti 1985; Acharya and Buzan 2007; Tickner and Wæver 2008).

The assumption that Third World knowledge of global realities is “different” is based upon surprisingly thin tangible evidence about the state of international relations thinking in other parts of the world.⁴ Furthermore, the majority of what the IR community does know has been authored by core scholars, and thus translated and rewritten in order to fit the social canons of western academia. That scant research has been conducted on how knowledge building in the field

¹I thank Bill Smith for his helpful comments.

²Although the concept of the “third world” has come under increased attack, I believe that it continues to preserve an important heuristic value that warrants its usage to describe common political resistance to dependence and similar structural problems created by insertion into the global capitalist system. I employ the term indistinctively with “non-core” and “periphery.” See Shohat (1992:11).

³The work actually done on IR theory and the third world has included: analyses of the misfit between numerous core concepts (among them, power, security, sovereignty, and the state) and narratives with peripheral realities and problems (Ayoob 1995; Blaney 1996; Inayatullah 1996; Neuman 1998; Tickner 2003a; Inayatullah and Blaney 2004); the examination of national and regional IR perspectives different from those of the United States and Europe (Acharya 1997; Cox 1997; Chan 1999; Rajaei 1999; Dunn and Shaw 2001; Geeraerts and Jeng 2001; Inoguchi and Bacon 2001; Euben 2002; Tickner 2003b); and the identification and analysis of representational practices in IR discourses and their role in perpetuating subordinate relations between core and periphery (Escobar 1995; Doty 1996).

⁴This problem is explored in depth in Bilgin (2008).

of IR takes place in peripheral settings, how it travels between core and non-core, which knowledge travels and which does not, and the ways in which knowledge itself is transformed in the process, is equally problematic.

Given Latin America's historical exposure to the political, economic, cultural, and intellectual influence of the United States and its cyclical attempts to disentangle itself from US domination, the region begs to be explored as one part of the non-core whose understandings of global realities have been overlooked (Tickner 2003b). Arguably, Latin America has fared somewhat better than the rest of the Third World. In the 1970s, the dependency perspective was hailed as an authentically local formula for interrogating core-periphery relations and their noxious effects upon development, and was flaunted by the United States and others as if it were a genuine Third World contribution. However, as Fernando Henrique Cardoso (1977), one of its founders once lamented, dependency's "discovery," importation, and consumption by first world academic circuits far-removed from—if not oblivious to—its intellectual, political, and geocultural context led to severe distortions in its original contents.

Building upon general accounts of IR studies in Latin America that I have developed elsewhere (Tickner 2002, 2003b), the objective of this article is to trace and explain the general historical development of IR thinking in the region. My primary concern is with identifying the ways in which intellectual, political, economic, social, and cultural factors have influenced this process. To this end, I discuss the ways in which state needs, foreign policy practices, the development of the social sciences, and US IR knowledge have influenced Latin American understandings of the "international" since the postwar period.⁵

Core-Periphery Relations, National Development, and the Latin American State

Between the 1930s and 1940s, rapid urbanization, industrialization, and economic growth led to economic, political, social, and cultural transformations that Latin American states were ill-equipped to manage (Wilhelmy 1980:177). Following World War II, the expansion of the global capitalist system and the birth of the cold war placed additional external demands upon the region. These changes led to a radical shift in the state's conception and highlighted the need for increased state intervention, expanded political participation, in particular of the middle and working classes, targeted goals for socioeconomic development, and limits upon oligarchic domination and foreign capital (Kaplan 1984:266). They also pointed to a new role for the social sciences, which were rarely considered credible sources of policy relevant knowledge. The institutionalization of fields such as economics, sociology, history, and anthropology between the 1950s and 1960s and their subsequent role in the provision of knowledge susceptible to being translated into public policy formulae was nurtured largely by local states (Cotler 1986; Sonntag 1988; Palacios 1999:68).

During this period, the United States also began to exercise greater intellectual influence in Latin America. The consolidation of the social sciences took place within a framework of cooperative relations with US universities, aid agencies, and foundations, as well as the training of the region's social scientists abroad (Wilhelmy 1980:173–174; Sonntag 1988:71). One of the main expressions of intellectual influence was modernization theory. According to this perspective, Latin America's problems were attributable to the absence of certain phases of the development process undergone in the countries of Western Europe and the United States. Its central hypothesis was that the values, institutions, and attitudes characterizing traditional society constituted the primary causes of underdevelopment, and that progress along the lines followed by the 'first' world

⁵See Wæver (1998) for a blueprint of this analytical strategy.

would lead to their replacement by modern ones (Valenzuela and Valenzuela 1978).

A key local by-product of changes within Latin American states and societies was the thinking developed by the Economic Commission for Latin America (ECLA). Diverging from modernization theory, ECLA sought to show that exogenous factors, namely, the international division of labor and the role occupied by the Latin American economies as primary goods exporters, produced asymmetrical relations between the large core countries and the nations of the periphery (United Nations, ECLA 1950). The Commission pointed to the need to implement inward-looking development strategies via import substitution industrialization and to strengthen regional integration mechanisms in order to overcome existing sources of disadvantage in the global economy. The elimination of large-landholding (*latifundio*) interests, the creation of an enlarged internal consumption market and the incorporation of the marginalized rural population also constituted central aspects of its proposal (Cardoso 1972:48).

Beyond its economic formulations, ECLA argued in favor of the need for a strong, active state in the redirection of Latin America's productive process. As was the case of modernization theory, tremendous faith was also placed in the role of the "modern" economic and political elite in spearheading development. This view was upheld by other institutions such as the Superior Institute for Brazilian Studies (ISEB), created in 1956 by the Brazilian state in order to foster front line academic analyses of the obstacles to development in that country. According to both agencies, a national capitalist "revolution," led by the progressive bourgeoisie and modern bureaucratic class and based upon an alliance with the working class, would result in the consolidation of the kind of national state that was considered indispensable to development (Bresser-Pereira 2006:424–426). Clearly, the underlying assumption of this argument was that state building and the claiming of sovereignty were necessary preconditions for overturning the core-periphery relations that drove underdevelopment.

The crisis of ISI in the early 1960s led to a series of critiques concerning the viability of the proposed development strategy. While growth achieved during its early phases was crucial for promoting and satisfying the increasing demands of the lower classes, the inability to make the transition to the secondary and capital production phases led to declining economic performance and full-blown crises in many countries. Moreover, ISI led to new types of dependence based upon foreign imports and investment. In addition to modifying the productive structure of the Latin American countries in a negative manner, Guillermo O'Donnell (1972) shows how dependent economic modernization and industrialization in Latin America, instead of producing conditions favorable to democracy, became associated with the rise of political authoritarianism in Brazil (1964), Argentina (1966, 1976), Chile (1973), and Uruguay (1973).

The "bureaucratic-authoritarian" regimes that rose to power with the support of national elite groups, large sectors of the middle classes and global actors, most importantly, the US government and multinational corporations, set off to restimulate economic growth in their respective countries by establishing new alliances with foreign capital and suppressing the rising demands of the popular classes through extensive repression.⁶ Ironically, although many intellectuals associated with both ECLA and ISEB hailed from the left, their nationalist-developmental discourse was well received by regional military governments driven by a strong state and nationalist development projects.

⁶Although other major countries such as Colombia, Mexico, and Venezuela survived this authoritarian interlude, they too fashioned elite pacts designed to dismantle popular demands.

The Authoritarian Interlude and Associated Dependent Development

Dependency writings grew out of a complex milieu characterized by the growing political commitment of many social scientists to radical social, political and economic change, increased US intervention in Latin America, and authoritarianism. For many, the 1959 Cuban revolution and the expansion of armed guerrilla movements throughout the region had driven local elites to abandon the national roadmap espoused by ECLA and ISEB and to join the US-led anti-communist alliance. Furthermore, elite group support of authoritarian regimes provided poignant evidence of the ambiguous and contradictory nature of the bourgeoisie in dependent countries and of their incapacity to be truly “national” (Cardoso 1971; Bresser-Pereira 2006:427–433).

Consequently, dependency authors sought to overturn existing knowledge concerning capitalism, modernization, development, social inequality, the state and the elite class, and in so doing, to amend regional social structures. Although they shared many of ECLA’s key assumptions concerning the unequal nature of exchange in the global economy and the resulting division of the world into core and periphery, most *dependendistas* rejected the reformist modernization project proposed by both it and ISEB, their confidence in the progressive role of the national bourgeoisie, and their focus on mainly external sources of underdevelopment. The principal problem with which dependency attempted to engage was the historically changing relationship between specific national and international structures of political and economic domination, and political alliances and struggles among distinct social groups (Cardoso and Faletto 1978:167).

Outside Latin America, the dominant (US) reading of the diverse authors, grouped together under the dependency label, was that they sought to explain the impact of global capitalism on economic underdevelopment in the periphery. Tellingly, in a seminal article on the consumption of dependency in the United States, Cardoso (1977) argued that significant distortion took place when dependency traveled north, entailing the invisibilization of those local internal problems of greatest concern to social scientists in Latin America and the prioritization of external factors such as US intervention and multinational corporations.

That imperialism and the external conditioning of the third world were considered vital factors explaining dependence was only natural, given growing criticism of US interventionism by scholars in both Latin America and the United States. The selective consumption of authors such as André Gunder Frank (1977), whose arguments concerning the development of underdevelopment and the zero-sum nature of capitalism were widely embraced, reinforced, albeit erroneously, the idea that the domestic manifestations of dependence, although worrisome, did not constitute causal variables. This conceptual move, although critical in intent, reproduced Latin America’s status as an object acted upon by exploitative agents in the core and blinded US analysts to the myriad ways in which local elites and states were active players in the dependence game.

Within the mix of industrialization, growth, skewed development, and later, authoritarianism that emerged within the larger Latin American countries between the 1940s and 1960s, many dependency writers set out to explore what they understood to be a markedly different stage of dependence. It was premised upon an international division of labor that highlighted the importance of the more industrialized economies in the region and the perverse ways in which development had unfolded there (Santos 1968, 1973; Cardoso 1972; Sunkel 1980). Contrary to prevalent assumptions that imperialism and dependency impeded growth in the periphery, the economic record of countries such as Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and Mexico suggested that development was not incompatible with dependency and that multinational corporate activity was

concentrated precisely where the potential for economic and technological growth was highest (Santos 1973).

Although constituting a motor of economic expansion, industrialization, urbanization, wealth, and consumption, it was observed that peripheral development worsened the political, economic, and social problems of the host country (Sunkel and Fuenzalida 1980:45). In addition to being highly exclusionary and unequal, development's democratizing effects were proven completely unfounded by the ascendance of military governments that set out to reverse positive structural change and to guarantee conditions conducive to foreign investment and capital accumulation.

Given the central interest of dependency (and ECLA and ISEB) in exploring the role of the state in securing development, the ways in which the new dependence deepened the internalization of capitalist logics and fashioned states that were at once representatives of the nation and non-sovereign instruments of global domination became a vital concern. The model, which Cardoso (1974) termed associated dependent development, was premised foremost on the ambivalent nature of the Latin American elite and its state bureaucracies, which were considered incapable of pursuing an inclusive national project given their permanent temptation to suppress structural change and to ally themselves with core countries and non-state capitalist actors (Cardoso and Faletto 1978:195; Bresser-Pereira 2006:432–433). In the absence of a national bourgeoisie the only path available to Latin America was to associate with the core and harness the potential benefits derived from complacent and close interaction. Therefore, associated dependent development led to new forms of strategic interaction and negotiation between the local bourgeoisie, the US multinational corporations and the Latin American states (Cardoso 1972:43–44).

IR Thinking and the Problem of Peripheral Autonomy

By placing Latin American ills firmly within the context of global capitalism and unequal exchange, and their dynamic relation to economic, political, and social factors in the domestic sphere, both dependency and its ECLA and ISEB (hereafter, nationalist–developmentalist) predecessors provided important cues for thinking about the region's IR, given their insights on capitalist exchange, the state, sovereignty, integration, and the role of the local elite (Tickner 2003b). However, contrary to the latter two frameworks, which attempted to provide a series of measures that the Latin American countries could adopt in order to overcome their peripheral status, dependency was highly pessimistic about this outcome.

Given that dependency writings were not easily convertible into state policy, especially in those variants that advocated socialist revolution, the founding fathers of Latin American IR considered them “paralyzing.” However, IR thinking in the region did seek to engage many of dependency's concerns about the state, its lack of sovereignty, the role of elite groups and the region's potential for outgrowing its dependent status. The growth of the field between the 1960s and 1980s largely responded to the need to reduce existing levels of political, economic and intellectual dependence, and to create autochthonous views that were suitable as guides to Latin American foreign policy (Lagos 1980; Muñoz 1980). In pursuing this objective, many authors believed that Latin America needed to “[...] create its own scientific knowledge, extracted from its respective reality, while developing its own theoretical and methodological instruments” (Perina 1985:12).

Although it was widely perceived that the dependency literature was inadequate for doing this, regional IR scholars also felt that the predominant United States IR theory, realism, was of limited relevance to the analysis and practice of

Latin American IR. From its onset, the study of IR in the region was characterized by the tension between incoming US influences and local formulations concerning global affairs. Interestingly, this tug of war was played out through the selective incorporation of Morgenthauian assumptions about the state, the statesman and the national interest into preexisting analytical frameworks, primarily nationalist–developmentalist and dependency thinking. The hybrid model that emerged from mixing bits and pieces of United States and Latin American theories created the foundations for a series of suppositions about Latin American foreign policy, peripheral state dependence and development that informed both academic and political practice throughout the region until the mid to late 1980s (Tickner 2002, 2003b).

Paradoxically, authoritarianism provided the initial venue for this process. Many social science institutions and programs were shut down or reformed to reflect the practical needs of the military governments, and thousands of scholars and political activists were forced into exile. The negation of public service as a viable professional alternative for members of the left also led many would-be politicians to engage in academic activities abroad. Following the 1964 military coup in Brazil, for example, a large number sought refuge in Chile, where many renowned radical dependency scholars, including Theotonio Dos Santos, Ruy Mauro Marini, Vania Bambirra, and André Gunder Frank, were received by the Center for Socioeconomic Studies (CESO) of the University of Chile. When the CESO and other Chilean institutions were crushed by the Pinochet regime, a large majority of exiles left for Mexico, where persons fleeing political persecution from Brazil and the Southern Cone came together. The joining of groups of critical scholars and activists from different latitudes allowed for the circulation and maturation of ideas concerning regional dependence, US imperialism, nation building, democracy, and civil-military relations, among others.

In the case of IR thinking, the creation of a regional network of scholars and academic centers in 1977, called the Joint Studies Program in International Relations in Latin America (RIAL) and spearheaded by Chilean, Argentine, Brazilian, and Mexican intellectuals cum practitioners linked to the preauthoritarian political establishment, was definitive in carving out the field's disciplinary niche and identity. The twin goals of RIAL were to foster interest in international studies on a regional level and to enhance Latin America's international negotiating capacity (RIAL 1985:4, 1988:2). United States support of and involvement in the South American military coups, and later, the Central American conflict, made capacity building in foreign affairs a vital priority. This concern was shared by like-minded individuals that headed up the ECLA and United Nations Development Project offices housed in Santiago, Chile. In 1980, they offered RIAL's academic coordinator a permanent home within ECLA's installations with funding provided by the latter organization. In the mid-1980s, the Ford Foundation also became an active supporter of the network's activities, and of individual IR programs throughout Latin America.

A key concern aired by this nascent IR community was related to the problem of Latin American autonomy. While admittedly, earlier nationalist–developmentalist proposals concerning autonomous capitalist development had proven misguided and were quashed by the military with the acquiescence of the dominant classes and the United States, autonomy continued to be viewed as a sine qua non for development and perhaps more importantly, for state and nation-building. Contrary to earlier periods in which US interventionism in the region was widespread, in the 1970s international affairs scholars were emboldened by the idea that US hegemony was in decline. The oil crises of 1973 and 1979 also cultivated a generalized feeling of hopefulness concerning Latin America's potential weight as a global player. On the domestic front, although it was acknowledged that local elites were perennially torn between building a national project and

allying themselves with the core, it was widely believed that the need to return to democracy would secure commitment to the former.

The literature on autonomy produced in Latin America between the late 1970s and mid-1980s made eclectic use of existing local know-how, mainly nationalist–developmentalist and dependency analysis, and US IR theories, particularly classical realism and interdependence. The picking and choosing of useful categories from distinct analytical frameworks made the autonomy idea conceptually and symbolically different from both its Latin American and northern parents. Two authors, Helio Jaguaribe (one of the founders of Brazil's ISEB) and Juan Carlos Puig (an ex-minister of Argentine foreign relations who relocated in Venezuela after the 1976 coup), were particularly influential in the development of the autonomy concept in the region. Plus, through the network established by RIAL an entire body of thought on autonomy was elaborated; it traveled extensively and was incorporated into the field's lexicon region wide (Tickner 2002, 2003b).

Undoubtedly, one of main contributions of the nationalist–developmentalist and dependency frameworks to IR thinking was to show how the global division of labor and the internal manifestations of external capitalist dynamics worked to negate Latin American state sovereignty by eroding its development potential. Therefore, the over riding concern all of the literature on autonomy was to identify the potential sources of external, internal, economic, and political autonomy, and to design effective strategies for achieving its full potential. In this regard, autonomy became an “idea-force” (Russell and Tokatlian 2003:6) that underwrote the intellectual–political IR condominium. From the outside in, autonomy came to be equated with statehood and the nation, and was viewed as the primary means of securing distinct forms of non-dependent or autochthonous development. And from the national borders outward, it was considered an instrumental tool for practicing Latin American international politics, given its role in safeguarding the region against the most noxious effects of the global system (Tickner 2003b).

According to this view, autonomy is a function of structural conditions that Jaguaribe (1979:96–97) describes as “national viability” and “international permissibility,” consisting of adequate human and material resources, the capacity for international exchange, local sociocultural cohesion, and the ability to neutralize external threats. Technical–entrepreneurial autonomy and favorable relations with the core are also identified as prerequisites for autonomous action. Dependence had constrained national viability by inscribing the Latin American countries into an unfavorable global division of labor. International permissibility entailed political strategies cognizant of established boundaries and rules of the game in Latin America's relations with the United States in exchange for US acquiescence in matters related to local development. For Jaguaribe and other international analysts, the record of US intervention in countries adopting confrontational policies that threatened the hegemon's strategic economic and political interests warranted a more cautious and moderate stance. Similar to Jaguaribe's discussion of this problem, for Puig (1980) autonomy requires adequate degrees of national viability, a sufficient amount of domestic resources, and an explicit commitment on the part of elite groups to pursue autonomy-maximizing policies.

The influence of dependency approaches on the autonomy literature is manifest primarily in descriptions of the international system, which is characterized in terms of hierarchical relations of domination and the role of global forces in constraining both the foreign and domestic policies of the region's countries. However, in contrast to the core–periphery structure set forth by dependency (and ECLA), Jaguaribe (1979:91–93) portrays the world order as a differentiated system in which distinct states occupy varied positions based upon their territorial integrity, self-determination and capacity to sanction eventual aggressors, and not just their role in the global division of labor.

Another factor that distinguished autonomy writings from dependency and brought it closer to the nationalist–developmentalist stance was their faith in the role of progressive, national elites in mobilizing state resources in favor of autonomy-seeking domestic and foreign policy strategies. To a certain degree, this view coincides with Hans Morgenthau's (1968) portrayal of the statesman as an enlightened, prudent individual who establishes policy goals and executes them in accord with the national interest; it may explain the appeal of Morgenthauian realism for the authors of the autonomy approach and for the IR community in general. The Latin American reading of realism helped strengthen the argument that a strong elite role in matters of public policy was indispensable. The fact that the state was viewed as the principal domain of political, social, and economic regulation, the main expression of the "nation" and a key symbol of national sovereignty and independence also facilitated the incorporation of Morgenthau's arguments concerning its role as the ultimate arbiter of the national interest. Given that efforts within IR studies and other social science fields, particularly in South America, were geared largely towards rethinking the state and nation-building enterprise, the idea that foreign policy efforts should attempt to secure "national" concerns provided a particularly good fit.

A second aspect borrowed from classical realism was its concern with power, although it was replaced with a more suitable concept for the region, namely autonomy. Whereas power serves to influence others' actions in accord with a particular actor's interests (Morgenthau 1968:9), autonomy constitutes an instrument for defending national sovereignty and development, controlling the activities of transnational actors, enhancing international negotiating capacities, and upholding other interests vis-à-vis stronger actors within the international system. On a domestic level, autonomy is the foundation of the nation-state's viability, understood as the capacity of the state to exercise its political, economic, military, technological, and cultural functions (Jaguaribe 1979).

Interdependence too, in particular Keohane and Nye's (1977) work, was readily incorporated into Latin American discussions of autonomy given its openness towards economic and social issues, and its acknowledgement of transnational actors as key global players. By relativizing the concept of power in terms of multiple sources and actors, interdependence also gave the upbeat impression that the scope of action of peripheral countries, particularly those in possession of strategic natural, economic, and political resources, and/or effective negotiating skills, had increased.

That the autonomy discourse—formulated mainly by leftist-leaning intellectuals, many of whom were forced into exile—was attractive to distinct and even opposing political factions throughout Latin America is no small irony. The nation, state and power-based language that it employed allowed for engagement and communication with the geopolitical discourse of distinct military governments and their staunchly nationalist orientation, as well as with that of the Institutional Revolutionary Party (PRI)-controlled Mexican state and semi-democratic governments elsewhere (Tickner 2002). While the shift in Latin American foreign policy towards relative assertiveness during the 1970s seemed to confirm many of the literature's hypotheses, the fact that relative sovereignty, autonomy, and national interests were being sought out in the name of non-democratic governments was highly controversial.

Neoliberalism, Democratization, and the End of the Cold War

Latin American activism in the international system contrasted with obstacles to economic growth brought on by the debt crisis in the early 1980s. Following several failed attempts to establish a debtor's cartel, the countries of the region faced severely reduced margins of maneuverability in addressing this problem

and gradually acceded to the demands of the international financial community. The debt crisis led to a fundamental rethinking of the state's role and of the causes of underdevelopment. Namely, the unequal logic of capitalism and market flaws that the nationalist–developmentalist model had faulted for regional ills were replaced by accusations that the state constituted the major obstacle to development and well-being, given its size, inefficiency, and corruption (Palacios 1999:55). Drawing upon this argument, neoliberal prescriptions for economic reform that came into vogue called for granting the market free reign via reduced state intervention, trade and investment liberalization, privatization, and fiscal decentralization.

In addition to a deep-seated revisioning of the state, this paradigm shift led to the ascendance of “practical” and “non-ideological” knowledge purportedly designed to increase efficiency, enhance competitiveness, and synchronize regional economies and political systems with the demands of the global market. The field that best illustrates this view of intellectual activity is economics, in which a generation of technocrats trained abroad positioned themselves as authoritative experts by invoking the superiority of their scientific and technical capacities. Its self-perception as a policy elite allowed the technocracy to prioritize economic recovery and growth and the reestablishment of order while extricating itself from social responsibility of any kind (Centeno and Silva 1997). However, other areas of the social sciences were not immune to this process in that they too experienced a shift from structural, normative analyses of the “big picture” in Latin American societies towards more focused, empirical exercises more functional to the needs of the state (Sorj 1990:109). For many, the lack of political commitment, characteristic of this stage of the social sciences, and their role in legitimating and sustaining the new social order signaled the beginning of a profound crisis.

The “lost decade” and subsequent neoliberal wave coincided with a strategy to reestablish US hegemony worldwide, one of the cornerstones of which was an all-out “war on communism” in Central America and the Caribbean. Although the Contadora Group was created in 1983 by Mexico, Venezuela, Colombia, and Panama in order to seek a regionally led negotiated settlement in the Central American crisis, counteracting US interventionism there proved difficult. The US decision to side with Great Britain in the 1982 Malvinas/Falkland war, notwithstanding massive Latin American support for Argentina, reinforced the region’s political vulnerability (Van Klaveren 1992:24). Latin America’s bid for autonomy was further eroded with the end of the cold war, which deprived the region of a threatening “other” through which to counteract US influence. This process was sealed with the definitive transition to democracy in Brazil and the Southern Cone and the Central American peace accords. The combination of factors—neoliberalism, democratization, and end of the bipolar conflict—led to more subdued, inward looking strategies in Latin American foreign policy.

In spite of its longstanding role as an “idea force” in Latin American IR thinking and foreign policy practice, by the 1990s academic production in the region on the topic of autonomy was non-existent. According to Argentine scholar Carlos Escudé (1995), in Latin American foreign policy autonomy became an end in itself, ultimately competing with other important national goals, including economic development. The fact that autonomy was exercised in the name of nationalist interests ultimately proved harmful to the local populace and in particular, to subordinate groups, given that it was used to strengthen the state apparatus and to serve dominant class interests. Also, autonomy led to confrontational attitudes vis-à-vis the United States that the hegemon subsequently punished, thus eroding state capacity in the region.

According to Escudé (1995:208–211), the two main fallacies of dependency thinking and subsequent writings on autonomy were to assume that autonomy was a prerequisite for development and, conversely, that dependence led to

underdevelopment. The author sustains the opposite view that development and wealth are indispensable for autonomy. This formula, which comes remarkably close to the associated dependent development model, calls for a foreign policy strategy in which the Latin American countries would be well advised to eliminate sources of friction with the US and other core powers when their material interests are not directly at stake; to avoid “idealist” but costly decisions, such as the condemnation of United States interventionism, or the defense of sovereignty or democracy; and to bandwagon with the dominant power or a coalition of great powers (Escudé 1995:154–156).

Although circulation of “peripheral realism” was largely limited to the Southern Cone, its critique of autonomy and its calls for a more cautious international stance provide a fairly accurate picture of many Latin American states’ and much of the IR community’s prevailing mood during the 1990s. Both nationalist–developmentalist and dependency thinking had lost their purchase in the region whereas problems of global insertion, competitiveness, and democratic governance were front and center. Economic and political integration, which were viewed earlier as a political tool for enhancing regional autonomy, were pursued by regional states and studied by international relations analysts in terms of their capacity to maximize globalization’s full potential, suggesting conformity and compatibility with the existing global order (Tickner 2003b:345–346). Given concern with lingering military influence in the security realm, particularly in Brazil, the Southern Cone, and postconflict Central America, security and defense studies linked to democratic governance problems and the rule of law also gained in importance.

These tendencies were reinforced by the prevalent view that the urgent, “real world” problems faced by the countries of Latin America made theory and “ideology charged” debate, such as that allegedly practiced by intellectuals between the 1960s and 1980s, a useless luxury that had little productive value. The fact that many of IR’s key figures abandoned academic practice to become politicians and public servants reinforced fondness for practical knowledge easily convertible into public policy recommendations.

The Crisis of Neoliberalism and the Return of the State

A series of recent developments seem to be influencing IR thinking in ways different from the post-Cold War period. Over the past decade the region has experienced a generalized crisis attributed largely to neoliberalism, which has been held accountable for alarming levels of poverty and inequality, varied degrees of institutional weakness and ungovernability, and rising public insecurity. Growing US unilateralism and imperialist attitudes following 9/11 have exacerbated anti-American sentiments throughout much of Latin America. Rising popular resistance movements, and support for both hard-handed military strategies, such as in Colombia, and leftist governments are also the result of high levels of dissatisfaction with the current social, political and security orders.

These changes are placing new demands upon Latin American states for which they require new knowledge. In IR one likely outcome is the revival of autonomy and development-based discourses, fashionable in the 1970s and 1980s and renewed emphasis on the state’s role in addressing popular demands via its foreign relations. Ideological rifts within Latin America itself, between pro-US governments in Mexico, Colombia, Central America, and much of the Caribbean; the leftist, anti-globalization, anti-US governments of Venezuela, Cuba, Bolivia, Ecuador, and Nicaragua; and a leftist-center block led by Brazil, Chile, and Argentina, point to several ways in which this discourse might be articulated.

The latter group of countries has begun to adopt pragmatic economic policies that combine promarket attitudes with efforts to respond to the socioeconomic

and political demands of the local population. According to Russell and Tokatlian (2003:12–13), the integration model that they have applied highlights the need to strengthen political, commercial, financial, and investment links with global power centers through joint Latin American efforts. This strategy, defined as “relational autonomy” by the authors, emphasizes the importance of stronger regional relations for enhanced decision making and action capacities deemed crucial for satisfying other objectives such as security, democratic strengthening, and welfare. Conversely, in the anti-globalization block led by Venezuela anti-imperialist and dependency discourses have begun to resurface (Beigel 2006). Notwithstanding the enormous divide that separates these two political projects, it is interesting that, in both cases, considerations concerning the role of the state in Latin American societies have reclaimed the academic spotlight.

Conclusions

The portrait offered here suggests that, although Latin American IR has not completely mirrored developments in the United States, many of its core concerns, including the state, sovereignty, power, and security, certainly parallel them. And yet, when looking at similar categories Latin American scholars have normally seen something different.

As I have suggested throughout the text, conceptual and thematic preferences in the field have been molded by a number of political, economic, and social factors, among them domestic state interests and needs, foreign policy practices, developments within the local social sciences, and diverse forms of interaction with the United States. Conceptually speaking, the genetic imprint out of which Latin America IR grew was rooted in local theories of political economy, namely the nationalist–developmentalist and dependency schools, and US IR theories, primarily Morgenthauian realism and to a lesser extent, interdependence. The marriage of these unusual bedfellows may explain the relative lack of differentiation that exists between IR and comparative politics, as well as the fuzzy distinction that regional scholars make between the international and the domestic spheres.

As in the case of other areas of the social sciences, IR studies in the region were also constituted through their involvement in the political domain; they continue to operate primarily through diverse forms of articulation with the policy world. What this means is that the “ivory tower” autonomy that separates Western scholars from the “real world” is absent in the Latin American context. In fact, those regional scholars who do attempt to distance themselves from events on the ground are normally scorned for being “too academic.” The primacy of practical knowledge susceptible to being translated into policy formulae, and the scarcity of theoretically inclined scholarship in IR are largely derived from this condition.

Finally, the field’s subservience to state cues, coupled with the deep historical roots of the state in the collective imaginary, may explain why nearly all Latin American analyses of international issues assign primordial status to this actor. Although the state and concepts such as sovereignty have become highly problematic within the field of IR and in global practice itself, Latin American scholarship, buttressed by regional states and societies, continues to cherish them.

A somewhat troubling discovery suggested by this discussion is that IR, as it is professed in non-core settings such as Latin America, offers relatively little of the kinds of alternative knowledge that critical scholarship so eagerly seeks. Explaining why this might be the case and staking a claim, in spite of it, to the importance of further inquiries into the evolution of IR thinking throughout the world constitutes an enterprise that is sorely needed.⁷

⁷See Tickner and Wæver (in press) for an attempt to contribute to this debate.

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